A RECORDS ORGANIZER

The Family Records Organizer

Everything your family will need to know, and where to find it

FILL IN ONCE. TELL SOMEONE. REVIEW IT EVERY YEAR.

ABOUT THIS BOOK

This is a record-keeping aid. It is a place to write down what you have, where it is kept, who should be told, and what you would prefer. It is not a legal, financial, tax or medical document, and completing it does not create a will, a trust, a power of attorney, a healthcare directive or an estate plan.

Nothing in these pages should be read as advice about your own circumstances. Where a question can only be answered by a qualified professional, or by the rules of the state or country you live in, this book says so and leaves the answer to them.

This book never asks you to write down a password, PIN, recovery phrase, private key or authentication code, and no page in it is designed to hold one. It records where such things are kept — nothing more.

First edition.

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Printed in black ink on white paper. Trim 8.5 × 11 in.

The interior is laid out for a perfect-bound paperback. It does not lie flat, and the book does not claim that it does. Page 101 explains how to work with that.

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PART 01

01

Getting started

Four decisions turn a blank book into a record your family can actually use. They take about twenty minutes, and everything else in this organizer depends on them.

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Why this organizer exists

Most families do not lose track of the house. They lose track of everything that sits behind a sign-in, a filing cabinet, or a memory nobody wrote down.

Ask someone where their will is kept and most people can answer. Ask where the deed is, which insurer holds the life policy, whether the pension has a named beneficiary, and what the password manager is secured with, and the answers thin out quickly. None of that is a failure of care. It is simply that no single place was ever given the job of holding it.

This book is that place. It is not a diary and it is not a filing cabinet. It is a map of both — a written record of what exists, where it lives, and who is allowed to know.

It is worth being plain about what a few hours with this book saves. It does not prevent anything. What it does is remove guesswork from a week when nobody has the energy to guess.

THREE THINGS THIS BOOK DOES

- It records locations, not secrets

  Where the document is, not what it says. Where the sign-in is held, not the sign-in. This keeps the book safe to leave in a house.

- It gives the reader an order

  The First 48 Hours pages are written for the person who opens this book in the worst week of their life. They are not written for you.

- It expects to be out of date

  Accounts close, insurers change, people move. A review page and a change log are built in, because a record that is never updated quietly becomes wrong.

NOTES

How this book works

Nine parts. One of them is for you; the rest is for whoever needs it after you.

The book has three layers, and it helps to know which one you are writing in at any moment.

THE RECORDS	Parts 3 to 5	What exists. Accounts, policies, property, documents, digital services. Written once, then corrected as things change.
THE LOCATOR	Part six	Where each of those things is physically or digitally kept, and who else knows. Every record page carries a reference back to it.
THE ROUTINE	Parts 2, 7, 8	What someone should do, in what order — at the beginning, and then every year afterwards.

> **You do not have to finish this.** A half-filled organizer that someone knows about is worth far more than a perfect one nobody has seen. Fill in Part two and Part six first. Those two are what a family actually needs in a hurry. Everything else can be added over months, and most people will add it in bursts.

A SENSIBLE ORDER OF WORK

1 **FIRST SITTING, ABOUT 30 MINUTES**

The four rules, your trusted person, and the First 48 Hours page.

2 **SECOND SITTING, ABOUT AN HOUR**

The Document Locator. Work from the documents you can actually put your hands on.

3 **THIRD SITTING, ABOUT TWO HOURS**

Records — banks, insurance, property, digital accounts. Do one section per evening.

4 **LATER, UNHURRIED**

Final wishes, letters, and the maintenance pages.

The four rules

Four rules govern the whole book. They are short on purpose.

01 **Write in pencil, or very lightly in pen.**

This is a living record, not a certificate. Things change. A page you are willing to correct is worth more than a page you are afraid to touch.

02 **Never write a password, PIN, recovery phrase, private key or authentication code.**

Record where those are kept and who can reach them. Nothing in the physical world is private once it is written down. A book on a shelf is not a vault, and it should not pretend to be one.

03 **Tell at least two people this book exists, and where you keep it.**

The single most common way a records organizer fails is that nobody knew it was there. A perfect record that is never found is a blank page.

04 **Review it once a year, and write down that you did.**

The review pages in Part seven take ten minutes. An out-of-date locator sends someone to a drawer that was emptied three years ago.

Rule two deserves one more sentence, because it is the rule people ignore. A password written in a book protects nothing once the book leaves the house, is photographed by a visitor, or is sold in a house clearance. What actually protects an account is a named setting inside the account itself, or a password manager whose own access is held somewhere deliberately. Part five deals with all of it without asking you to write anything secret.

Choosing your trusted person

This is the most important page in the book and it takes three minutes. Everything else is admin by comparison.

The trusted person is the first person you would want to have this book in their hands. They do not need to be your executor, your next of kin, or your closest relative. They need to be three things: willing, reachable, and able to keep something to themselves.

THE THREE TESTS

- ☐ **Willing** — You have asked them, and they said yes. Not assumed. Asked.
- ☐ **Reachable** — If they changed their phone number tomorrow, you would still be able to reach them within a day.
- ☐ **Discreet** — They would not read this book for interest, and would not tell siblings, neighbours or family friends what is in it.

YOUR TRUSTED PERSON

NAME _____ RELATIONSHIP TO ME _____

PHONE _____ EMAIL _____

ADDRESS _____

THEY KNOW THIS BOOK IS KEPT AT _____ DATE I ASKED THEM _____

> **A second person.** Name one more person who should know this book exists, even if they will never need to use it. If your first contact is on the same flight, in the same house, or simply unreachable that week, a second name turns a plan into a plan that works.

SECOND PERSON — NAME _____

SECOND PERSON — PHONE OR EMAIL _____

WHERE THIS BOOK IS KEPT (BE SPECIFIC: ROOM, SHELF, BOX) _____

Keeping it secure

This book is deliberately useful to a stranger, which is exactly why it should be hard for a stranger to find.

Because the book records locations rather than contents, losing it is inconvenient rather than catastrophic. It tells a burglar where your documents are, not what is in them. Still, a little care is worth taking, and most of it costs nothing.

PHYSICAL SECURITY

- [ ] Keep the book somewhere you would remember in the dark — not in a safe you would have to remember a combination for.
- [ ] Keep it out of the room a visitor would naturally sit in.
- [ ] If you use a safe or a locked drawer, record its location in Part six, and not its combination anywhere in this book.
- [ ] Tell your trusted person the room and the shelf, not just the house.
- [ ] If you move house, update the location on the very next review page.

DIGITAL SECURITY, WITHOUT OVERENGINEERING IT

If any part of this book is photographed or scanned, store those images the way you would store a passport scan. A useful rule of thumb: anything you would not email to a stranger should not sit in an unencrypted folder called 'Documents'.

- [ ] Do not photograph pages that name your bank, insurer or account references.
- [ ] Keep any scanned copy inside a password-protected account, not a shared drive.
- [ ] If you use a password manager, its recovery kit belongs somewhere physical and separate from this book — not inside it.
- [ ] Never send a photograph of these pages in a group message.

> **A note on what is not here.** There is no page in this book for a password, a PIN, a recovery phrase, a private key or a one-time code. That is a design decision, not an omission. Part five shows you how to record everything a family actually needs — which service, what it is for, and who can get to it — without ever writing down the thing that unlocks it.

What this can and cannot do

An organizer that overstates itself is worse than no organizer, because someone will rely on it.

WHAT IT CAN DO

- ☐ Tell your family what exists and where it is kept.
- ☐ Give someone an order of work in the first two weeks.
- ☐ Record your preferences clearly enough to be acted on.
- ☐ Show which documents you have and which you do not.
- ☐ Point you at the official places to replace a missing record.

WHAT IT CANNOT DO

- ☐ It does not create a will, a trust, a power of attorney, a healthcare directive or an estate plan.
- ☐ It does not transfer ownership of anything to anyone.
- ☐ It does not override a will, a beneficiary designation or a court order.
- ☐ It does not prove identity, age or citizenship.
- ☐ It does not replace advice from a lawyer, accountant or financial adviser.

> **The line that matters.** What you write in Part four is a record of your preferences. Whether any of it is legally binding depends on documents prepared and signed in the way your state or country requires — not on anything written in this book. Part four explains the difference and tells you which items usually need a professional.

IF YOU HAVE NO WILL AT ALL

Then this book is a starting point, not a substitute. It will help you arrive at a lawyer's office knowing what you own, who you want to provide for, and which documents already exist — which is most of the work. Rules for who inherits when someone dies without a will vary by state and country, and are decided by statute, not by preference. That is a conversation for a qualified professional where you live.

NOTES

A simple document system

You do not need a filing system. You need one place, one naming habit, and one list that tells someone else where the place is.

Most people already have the documents. What they lack is a location that someone else can be told. Three small decisions fix that.

1 Choose one physical home

A box, a drawer, a filing cabinet — one place, not four. It does not need to be locked. It needs to be findable. Write its location on the next page, and in the Locator in Part six.

2 Choose one digital home

A single folder for scans, named for what it is, inside an account that is password-protected. Not the desktop, not a camera roll, not a shared drive.

3 Keep one list

That is the Document Locator. One row per document: what it is, where the original is, and who else knows. Everything else in this book refers back to it.

MY TWO HOMES

WHERE THE ORIGINALS LIVE — BE SPECIFIC ENOUGH THAT A STRANGER COULD FIND THEM

IS IT LOCKED?

IF LOCKED, WHO ELSE HAS ACCESS

WHERE THE DIGITAL COPIES LIVE — WHICH ACCOUNT, WHICH FOLDER

WHO ELSE CAN OPEN THAT ACCOUNT, AND HOW WOULD THEY KNOW

> **Do not reorganise your house today.** The temptation is to buy folders and start sorting. Don't. Choose the box you already have, write down where it is, and move on. The value is in the written location, not the tidiness.

Before you start

A short checklist to close Part one. If you do these six things, the book already works — everything after this is detail.

DATE

- ☐ I have read the four rules and I understand why there are no password fields. _____
- ☐ I have asked a trusted person, and they said yes. _____
- ☐ I have written down where this book is kept. _____
- ☐ I have told a second person the book exists. _____
- ☐ I have written where my documents live and where my digital copies live. _____
- ☐ I have booked a date to come back to this book. _____

MY NEXT SITTING IS ON _____

I WILL START AT _____

THE ONE THING I MOST WANT THIS BOOK TO SOLVE

One last thing before Part two. If you stop here and never write another page, what you have already done still matters: two people know this book exists, it says where your documents are, and it says where the copies are. That is not nothing. It is most of the way.

NOTES

The one-page summary

If a family member opens this book and has five minutes, this is the page to read. Fill it in last, from what you have already written.

> Everything below is repeated somewhere else in this book.
> This page exists so nobody has to read the whole thing to find it.

THIS BOOK BELONGS TO

DATE COMPLETED

IT IS KEPT AT

SECOND COPY, IF ANY

TRUSTED PERSON

PHONE

SECOND PERSON WHO KNOWS

PHONE

MY WILL IS HELD BY

PAGE IN THIS BOOK

THE DOCUMENT LOCATOR STARTS ON PAGE

DIGITAL RECORDS ON

WHO TO CALL FIRST

PAGE IN THIS BOOK

THREE THINGS A READER SHOULD KNOW ABOUT ME

Keep this page current. When anything on it changes, change it here first and then on the page it came from — this is the page that will actually be read.

NOTES

The ten-minute start

For the reader who has opened this book and does not want to read three pages before writing anything. Do these four things and stop.

1 Write where this book will live

One place, described well enough that a stranger could find it. Not 'the study' — the second shelf of the bookcase by the window.

2 Write one name

The person you would want holding this book. You do not have to ask them today, but the name is the hard part and it takes a minute.

3 Write one phone number

The person above. Without a number, a name in a book is only half useful.

4 Write one line about your will

Who holds the signed original, or 'I do not have one'. Either answer is worth more than a blank line.

WRITE THEM HERE

THIS BOOK LIVES AT

NAME **PHONE**

MY WILL IS HELD BY

> **Then stop.** Four lines is a real start, and it is more than most people ever do. The rest of this book is designed to be added to over months. Come back when you have an hour, not when you feel guilty.

NOTES

PART 02

02

The first 48 hours

This part is not written for you. It is written for the person who opens this book the day after you die, when they are tired, upset, and being asked questions they cannot answer.

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The first 48 hours

One page. Eight steps, in order. Nothing here is urgent that is not marked urgent.

> If you are reading this because someone has died, start here. Work down the list.
> Do not read the rest of the book yet. Nothing here needs a decision today.

1. Call the first person named

   Their name and number are on the next page. You do not have to do this alone.

2. Find the will, if there is one

   Its location is in the Locator. Do not remove it from where it is kept unless you need to.

3. Get certified copies of the death certificate

   Usually arranged by the funeral home. Ask how many they recommend — several institutions will each want an original.

4. Secure the home, the vehicle and any pets

   Lock up, collect the post, and make sure animals are fed and safe.

5. Tell the employer, if there is one

   Ask them to hold final pay and to explain any death-in-service benefits.

6. Tell the bank, but do not empty the account

   Ask them to flag the account. Joint accounts and named beneficiaries may work differently — ask before you act.

7. Do not pay, promise or distribute anything yet

   Not a debt, not a bill, not an heirloom. You are not obliged to decide today, and some payments cannot be undone.

8. Nothing else is urgent

   Everything in the rest of this book can wait a week. So can most of the people who will contact you.

If you are the person who wrote this book: read that list again and check that each step can actually be completed from what you have written. If a step says 'see the Locator' and the Locator row is blank, that is the single most useful correction you can make today.

Who to call first

Three people, in order. If the first cannot be reached, the second is called. That is the whole instruction.

FIRST CALL

NAME _____ RELATIONSHIP _____

PHONE _____ EMAIL OR OTHER _____

SECOND CALL

NAME _____ RELATIONSHIP _____

PHONE _____ EMAIL OR OTHER _____

THIRD CALL

NAME _____ RELATIONSHIP _____

PHONE _____ EMAIL OR OTHER _____

ALSO USEFUL IN THE FIRST WEEK

EMPLOYER — CONTACT _____ PHONE _____

FUNERAL HOME, IF ALREADY CHOSEN _____ PHONE _____

NEIGHBOUR OR BUILDING CONTACT _____ PHONE _____

PET CARER, IF ANY _____ PHONE _____

> **Why three, and why in order.** In a crisis, a list of twelve names is a list of nobody. Three names in a stated order removes the pause where someone wonders whether it is their place to call.

NOTES

Where the essentials are

The short version of the Document Locator: the seven things a family needs in the first week, and where each one is.

DOCUMENT	EXACTLY WHERE IT IS	WHO ELSE KNOWS	VERIFIED
Will or trust			
Death certificate instructions			
Photo identification			
Birth certificate			
Deed or lease			
Vehicle title			
Insurance policies			

The full locator, with forty categories, begins on page 82.

> **If a row is empty, that is information too.** A blank row tells you which document you do not have before a crisis forces the question. Part six shows where to get a replacement, and which office issues it.

NOTES

Who to notify

Not everyone needs telling in the same week. Sorting your list by when, rather than who, is the kindest thing you can do for the person making the calls.

TELL IN THE FIRST TWO DAYS

NAME	RELATIONSHIP	PHONE	TOLD

TELL IN THE FIRST TWO WEEKS

NAME	RELATIONSHIP	PHONE	TOLD

Organisations are different. Their order and method change from year to year, so this book does not reproduce it. The official list of who must be told, and which benefits stop, is maintained by USAGov and is worth reading on the day rather than trusting a printed version — see page 111.

The first two weeks

A second checklist, for when the funeral is over and the admin begins. Tick, date, and do not worry about the order.

DATE

- ☐ Read the will and note who is named as executor or personal representative.
- ☐ Ask a lawyer whether the estate needs to go through a court process — this varies by state and cannot be answered from a book.
- ☐ Notify the bank, building society or credit union, and ask how each account is held.
- ☐ Ask each insurer what they need in order to start a claim.
- ☐ Contact the pension providers and ask about named beneficiaries.
- ☐ Notify any employer, and ask about final pay and death-in-service benefits.
- ☐ Notify the Social Security Administration, and ask about survivor benefits.
- ☐ If the person served, contact the Department of Veterans Affairs.
- ☐ Forward the post, or ask a neighbour to collect it.
- ☐ Notify the three credit reporting agencies.
- ☐ Find the subscriptions that are still being charged, and stop the ones you can reverse.
- ☐ Make a list of what you have found, and keep it with this book.

NOTES

What can safely wait

Permission is part of the design. Most of what will feel urgent in the first month is not.

Grief and administration arrive together, and administration is louder. It helps to know which decisions have a deadline and which only feel as though they do.

GENUINELY TIME-SENSITIVE

- ☐ Securing the home, the vehicle and any animals.
- ☐ Reporting the death where the law or an institution requires it.
- ☐ Stopping benefits that would otherwise be overpaid and later reclaimed.
- ☐ Telling the employer, if final pay depends on it.
- ☐ Any insurance claim with a stated notification window.

CAN WAIT WEEKS, OR LONGER

- ☐ Sorting personal possessions.
- ☐ Deciding what to do with furniture and clothing.
- ☐ Closing social media accounts or memorialising them.
- ☐ Cancelling memberships that do not renew automatically.
- ☐ Reading the rest of this book.
- ☐ Making any decision you are not ready to make.

> **One thing to be careful of.** Debt collectors sometimes contact relatives who assume they are responsible. Often they are not. The Consumer Financial Protection Bureau publishes free guidance on this, including how to dispute a debt and how to make a collector stop contacting you. It is worth reading before paying anything that is not clearly yours.

NOTES

What goes back, and what stops

Some things must be returned or cancelled, and a surprising number of them carry a penalty for delay. This page is a list to work down, not a set of instructions.

The rules differ by country and, in the United States, by agency and by state. What follows is what the official guidance says at the time of writing; where it can change, the book points you at the source rather than guaranteeing an answer.

☐ A passport	Returned to the State Department for cancellation. This also reduces the risk of identity theft, which is the main reason to do it promptly rather than eventually.
☐ A driving licence	Usually returned to the state licensing agency, though practice varies. Ask when you notify them.
☐ A Social Security payment	Benefits stop at death, and the payment for the month of death must be returned. If it arrived by direct deposit, ask the bank to return it; if it arrived as a cheque, do not cash it.
☐ A Medicare card	No return needed. Social Security notifies Medicare, and coverage ends automatically.
☐ A pension payment	Paid after the death, it is usually recovered. The administrator will tell you how, and whether a survivor benefit is due.
☐ A benefit claim	SNAP, housing assistance and similar state benefits usually end at death, and the state agency will say what it needs.
☐ A lease or tenancy	Not returned, but it does need attention: notice periods and liability differ, and the landlord is a creditor of the estate.
☐ A vehicle registration	Returned or transferred, depending on the state. The motor vehicle agency will say which.
☐ Post and deliveries	Redirected, not returned. A mail redirection is one of the cheapest ways to stop identity theft.

WHAT I WAS TOLD, AND BY WHOM

Nothing on this page is a deadline you can calculate from the book. Ask the agency, in one call, and write the answer above.

Documents you will be asked for

Institutions ask for the same short list, in the same order, and each wants its own copy. Working out how many you need before you start saves a second round of requests.

Certified copies of a death certificate are the ones that matter — photocopies are not accepted. Funeral homes usually order them, and the local department of health issues them where no funeral home is involved. Only certain family members may obtain one in most states, and some records become public after a set number of years that differs by state.

A WORKING ESTIMATE

	TYPICAL NUMBER	ORDERED
Social Security Administration	1	
Bank and building society	1 each	
Life insurance — each policy	1 each	
Pension and retirement providers	1 each	
Employer and HR	1	
Motor vehicle agency	1	
Property, deeds and mortgage	1–2	
Probate court	1–2	
Tax authority	1	
Each utility you are closing	1	
Each investment or brokerage account	1 each	

> **Ask for more than you think.** The usual advice is to request ten to twelve certified copies, and most families who run out wish they had asked for two or three more while they were already at the counter. The extra copies are cheaper than a second application, and no institution will accept a photocopy.

COPIES ORDERED _____ **FROM** _____

ORDERED ON _____ **ARRIVED** _____

WHERE THE SPARE COPIES ARE KEPT _____

Telling people: what to say

The calls nobody is prepared for. These are openers, not scripts to read out — the point is to have the first sentence ready so the rest can follow.

Most people put this call off for hours because they do not know how to begin it. Having a first sentence written down is usually enough. Say the news once, plainly, then stop and let the other person speak.

A close relative	"I have some very bad news. It's about [name]. They died [when]. I'm so sorry. I wanted you to hear it from me."
A friend of theirs	"I'm calling with bad news. [Name] has died. I thought you would want to know before you heard it somewhere else."
Their employer	"I'm calling about [name]. They died on [date]. I'm sorry to tell you this over the phone. Who should I speak to about what happens next?"
A neighbour or carer	"I wanted to let you know before you saw anything unusual. [Name] died on [date]. Thank you for everything you did for them."
A question you cannot answer	"I don't know yet. I'll tell you as soon as I do." — this is a complete answer, and it is allowed.

WHO I ASKED TO MAKE THE CALLS

CALL	WHO WILL MAKE IT	DONE	NOTES

One person making most of the calls, rather than several making some, prevents the same person being told three times and prevents anyone being told not at all.

The paperwork in the first month

A plain list of what actually arrives, roughly when, and what it asks for. Nothing here is a deadline you can set your watch by.

The volume of post in the first month surprises almost everyone. It is not a sign that anything has gone wrong; it is the ordinary machinery of institutions catching up. The useful habit is to open everything on one day of the week, and to write on the envelope what you did about it.

Death certificate copies

Arrive from the funeral home or the local department of health. Count them, and keep the spares together.

Letters from banks and insurers

Usually a claims or bereavement team, with a form and a list of what to send. Keep the reference number.

A letter about benefits

Social Security, Medicare, or a state agency, confirming that a payment has stopped or must be returned.

Bills addressed to the person who died

These keep arriving. Paying them is usually the estate's job, not a family member's personal debt.

A letter from a debt collector

You can ask in writing for verification, and a written dispute within 30 days stops collection contact until it is answered. Keep a copy of what you send.

A pension or annuity statement

Usually with a survivors' section. Ask what a surviving spouse or dependant is entitled to.

A property tax or insurance notice

These have real deadlines. Deal with them first if you deal with nothing else.

Something that looks like a scam

Death records are public in many places, and fraudsters read them. Never pay a fee to 'release' a benefit.

MY PAPERWORK DAY IS

WHERE UNOPENED POST GOES

PART 03

03

Family and personal records

What exists, and where it lives. This is the longest part of the book and the least urgent. Work through it one section at a time, with a statement or a policy in front of you.

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About me

The facts that appear on forms. This is the section strangers will ask for most often.

FULL LEGAL NAME

OTHER NAMES USED

DATE OF BIRTH

PLACE OF BIRTH — TOWN, STATE, COUNTRY

HOME ADDRESS

SINCE WHEN

PHONE

EMAIL

COUNTRY OF CITIZENSHIP

OCCUPATION

EMPLOYER, IF ANY

EMPLOYEE OR SELF-EMPLOYED

MARITAL STATUS

SPOUSE OR PARTNER — FULL NAME

MOTHER'S MAIDEN NAME

FATHER'S FULL NAME

CHILDREN AND DEPENDANTS

FULL NAME	DATE OF BIRTH	WHERE THEY LIVE	IN MY CARE?

Continue on a separate sheet if there are more than three.

> **A note on the mother's maiden name question.** It appears on this page because it appears on forms, and because a family member filling in a form later will otherwise have to guess. If a website uses that answer as a security question, do not treat this line as the place to record it — and consider changing the question. Part five covers security questions properly.

Identification documents

Numbers, issuing offices and locations. Record the last four digits where a number is sensitive — the family needs to know it exists, not to memorise it.

DOCUMENT	NUMBER — LAST 4	ISSUED BY	EXPIRES	ORIGINAL KEPT AT
Passport				
Driver licence or state ID				
Birth certificate				
Social Security card				
Marriage certificate				
Divorce decree				
Naturalisation or citizenship papers				
Military discharge (DD-214)				
Professional licence				
Other identification				

Replacing these has a route, and it is worth knowing before you need it. Birth, death, marriage and divorce records are held by the state or territory where the event happened, and the CDC maintains a directory of every issuing office. Passports are handled by the State Department. A Social Security card is replaced through the Social Security Administration. Page 111 lists where to start with each.

NOTES

Family and trusted contacts

The people a family will need to reach. Not a Christmas card list — the names that will actually be called.

NAME	RELATIONSHIP	PHONE	EMAIL	KNOWS BOOK

Add a tick in the last column only for people who have actually been told.

WHO IS WHO

EXECUTOR OR PERSONAL REPRESENTATIVE NAMED IN MY WILL	THEY KNOW?
GUARDIAN NAMED FOR ANY MINOR CHILD	THEY KNOW?
ATTORNEY HOLDING MY WILL, IF ANY	FIRM
NEXT OF KIN FOR HOSPITAL PURPOSES	RELATIONSHIP

If any of those named have not been told, that is the most valuable correction available on this page. A named executor who does not know they are named is a plan with a hole in it.

Professionals

The people who already hold a piece of the picture. One line each on what they are for, so a family member knows who to call about what.

ROLE	NAME	FIRM	PHONE	WHAT THEY HANDLE
Lawyer — estate				
Lawyer — other				
Accountant or tax preparer				
Financial adviser				
Insurance agent				
Banker or relationship manager				
Doctor				
Dentist				
Other				

This page is not about loyalty to a professional. It is about the two questions a family will ask in week one: who has a copy of the will, and who prepared the last tax return. If the answer is on this page, those two conversations take minutes instead of weeks.

Medical contacts

Where the records are and who holds them. This part records contacts and locations only — it contains no medical advice and nothing to be acted on clinically.

PRACTICE OR PROVIDER	WHAT FOR	PHONE	RECORDS KEPT AT

THE DOCUMENTS A HOSPITAL MAY ASK ABOUT

DOCUMENT	EXISTS?	WHERE KEPT	COPY WITH
Advance directive or living will			
Healthcare power of attorney			
Do not resuscitate order, if any			
Organ donation registration			
Medication list, current			

Whether these must be witnessed, notarised or signed by particular people differs by state, and sometimes by hospital. Ask the professional preparing them, not this book. This page only records that a document exists and where the signed original is kept.

Insurance

The single most commonly missing fact in an estate is which insurer holds which policy, and who is named as beneficiary.

TYPE	INSURER	POLICY — LAST 4	BENEFICIARY	AGENT	WHERE POLICY IS
Life					
Life — through employer					
Long-term care					
Homeowners or renters					
Motor vehicle					
Health					
Dental or vision					
Travel					
Umbrella or liability					
Other					

Why the beneficiary column matters most. A named beneficiary usually takes an insurance payout directly, without going through a court process, and the policy is not governed by what a will says. If the column is blank on your policy, or the person named has died, ask the insurer what happens — that is a fact about your policy, not a general rule. Checking it takes one phone call and is the highest-value thing on this page.

Real property

Land and buildings, and where the paperwork for each one lives. Vehicles and household suppliers have their own pages.

ADDRESS OR DESCRIPTION	HOW IT IS TITLED	MORTGAGE / LENDER	DEED IS AT	INSURANCE

'How it is titled' means sole, joint, tenants in common, in trust. It decides what happens next, and it is worth confirming with the deed rather than from memory.

IF YOU RENT OR LEASE

LANDLORD OR AGENT

PHONE

LEASE ENDS

DEPOSIT HELD BY

WHERE THE SIGNED LEASE IS

NOTICE PERIOD

ANYTHING ATTACHED TO THE PROPERTY

RIGHTS OF WAY, EASEMENTS OR SHARED ACCESS

DOCUMENTED WHERE

SERVICE CHARGES OR GROUND RENT

PAID TO

ANYTHING A BUYER, A SURVEYOR OR A FAMILY WOULD NEED TO KNOW ABOUT THIS PROPERTY

Two facts usually decide everything else about a property: how it is titled, and whether there is a mortgage. Both are on the deed and the mortgage statement, neither is reliably in anyone's memory.

Financial institutions

Which institution, which type of account, and who is named on it. Last four digits only — a family needs to know the account exists, not its number.

INSTITUTION	TYPE	LAST 4	HELD WITH	BENEFICIARY OR TOD	BRANCH OR ADVISER

'Held with' means joint owner, or sole. This single word decides how much of the rest of the process applies.

How an account is held — sole, joint, 'payable on death', in trust — usually matters more than what the will says, because many accounts pass outside a will entirely. This book cannot tell you what applies to your own accounts; your bank can, in one conversation, and the answer is worth writing on this page.

NOTES

Debts and regular payments

What goes out every month, so that a family can tell a necessary payment from a forgotten one.

WHO IS PAID	FOR WHAT	FREQUENCY	AUTO?	CANCEL / KEEP	REFERENCE

Include rent or mortgage, utilities, insurance premiums, subscriptions, loans and anything that renews without asking.

> **The most expensive forgotten thing.** Automatic renewals keep charging after a death, and a card can run up an overdraft for months before anyone notices. The 'cancel or keep' column is the one a family will actually use — decide it now, while you are calm, rather than leaving it to be guessed later.

ANYTHING A FAMILY SHOULD KNOW BEFORE PAYING A BILL HERE

Employment and benefits

Where the final pay, the pension and the death-in-service cover come from — and who at the organisation to ask.

CURRENT OR LAST EMPLOYER

EMPLOYEE NUMBER

HR CONTACT

PHONE OR EMAIL

PENSION SCHEME — PROVIDER

SCHEME REFERENCE

NAMED BENEFICIARY ON THE PENSION

WHERE RECORDED

DEATH-IN-SERVICE BENEFIT

MULTIPLE OF SALARY

UNION OR PROFESSIONAL BODY

MEMBERSHIP NUMBER

OTHER BENEFITS TO CHECK

- ☐ Final salary or wages still owed.
- ☐ Untaken holiday pay.
- ☐ Company shares, options or profit share.
- ☐ A retirement account held through an employer.
- ☐ A life insurance policy arranged through work.
- ☐ A trade or professional association death benefit.
- ☐ Any state or federal benefit currently being received.

Benefits and pension rules change, and this book deliberately does not restate them. What it records is where to ask. The employer and the pension provider will both want a death certificate reference; the funeral home usually supplies it.

NOTES

Vehicles and titled property

Anything with a title, a registration or a lien. These are the items that cause the most paperwork and the least warning.

VEHICLE OR ITEM	REG. NO.	TITLED TO	LOAN OR LIEN	TITLE IS AT	KEYS ARE AT

Include boats, trailers, caravans, motorcycles and anything else the state registers. A vehicle nobody knew about becomes a letter from the motor vehicle agency six months later.

WHERE THE SPARE KEYS ARE

INSURANCE ON THE VEHICLES

IS ANY VEHICLE ON A FINANCE AGREEMENT?

WITH WHOM

Who the vehicle is registered or titled to decides what happens to it, and a car titled to two people is not handled the same way as one titled to one. The motor vehicle agency can confirm it in a minute, and the answer belongs on this page.

NOTES

Memberships and organisations

The bodies that hold a record of you, pay out on your death, or expect to be told. Trade unions and professional bodies are the most commonly forgotten.

ORGANISATION	MEMBER NO.	WHAT IT PROVIDES	CONTACT	TOLD?

Look for death benefits, funeral payments, continuing cover for a spouse, and any pension attached to membership.

EDUCATION AND QUALIFICATIONS

INSTITUTION	QUALIFICATION	YEAR	WHERE THE CERTIFICATE IS

Certificates matter less than people expect, but proof of a professional qualification sometimes matters a great deal — particularly where a licence or registration is tied to it. If that applies to you, note it here and put the certificate somewhere you can name.

Household services and suppliers

The people who keep a house running, and the codes and contracts that go with it. Record where the code is held, never the code.

SERVICE	PROVIDER	ACCOUNT	PHONE	ENDS

Electricity, gas, water, internet, phone, waste collection, garden, cleaning, maintenance contracts, security monitoring.

ACCESS AND CODES

ALARM COMPANY	**CODE HELD WHERE**
SAFE OR LOCKBOX — MAKE AND LOCATION	**WHO CAN OPEN IT**
STORAGE UNIT OR LOCKER	**CONTRACT AND KEY**

An alarm code is a lock, not a record. The useful facts are the company and who else holds a key — both on the lines above, without a code in a book.

Home contents worth listing

Not an insurance schedule. A short list of the things a family would otherwise have to guess about — what is valuable, and where the proof of it lives.

WHAT IT IS	WHERE IT IS	ROUGH VALUE	RECEIPT OR PHOTO AT	INSURED?

Only the items that matter: jewellery, instruments, tools, art, collectibles, anything with a serial number.

WHERE THE PHOTOGRAPHS OF THESE ARE KEPT

POLICY COVERING THEM

A photograph of a room is worth more than a description of it. If you do nothing else on this page, photograph the rooms where the valuable things are and put the images with your other digital records — then write on this line where that folder is.

NOTES

Financial institutions

Sheet two of two. Continue from the previous page; the reference letters run on.

Continue only if you ran out of rows on the first sheet.

INSTITUTION	ACCOUNT TYPE	LAST 4	HELD WITH	BENEFICIARY OR TOD	BRANCH/ADVISER

☐ I HAVE MORE ACCOUNTS THAN THERE ARE ROWS HERE

I CONTINUED ON A SEPARATE SHEET, DATED _____

NUMBER OF ENTRIES RECORDED HERE _____

Two sheets is deliberate. Most households have between three and eight accounts that matter; a third sheet is a sign that the list should be split by institution rather than continued line by line.

Debts and regular payments

Sheet two of two. Anything that renews without asking, and anything with a balance.

WHO IS PAID	FOR WHAT	BALANCE	DUE	AUTO?	CANCEL / KEEP

☐ I HAVE MORE REGULAR PAYMENTS THAN ROWS HERE

I CONTINUED ON A SEPARATE SHEET, DATED _____

NUMBER OF ENTRIES RECORDED HERE _____

Debts do not disappear at death, and they do not become the family's personal responsibility either. What helps is a list: who is owed, how much, and whether the account was in one name or two. That is all this page is for.

People who help

The trades and services a household relies on. A family that has never lived in the house will not know who to call when the boiler stops, and a boiler always stops at the worst moment.

TRADE OR SERVICE	NAME OR FIRM	PHONE	WHAT THEY LOOK AFTER

Boiler and heating, electrician, plumber, roofer, gardener, cleaner, locksmith, chimney sweep, appliance repair, IT help.

CONTRACTS AND GUARANTEES

BOILER OR HEATING CONTRACT

RENEWS

ANY WARRANTY STILL RUNNING

PAPERWORK IS AT

THE ONE NUMBER A FAMILY SHOULD CALL FIRST IF SOMETHING BREAKS

Write the trade's own mobile number rather than the office number where you have it. In practice it is the person, not the firm, who remembers the boiler.

Making an insurance claim

What an insurer will ask for, in the order they ask for it. Knowing the list in advance turns a fortnight of letters into one envelope.

Every insurer is different, and none of this is a substitute for their own letter. What follows is the shape of the request in almost every life or property claim, which is useful to know before the letter arrives.

☐ Proof of death	Usually a certified copy of the death certificate. Some insurers accept a funeral director's statement first.
☐ The policy number	From the schedule, not the certificate. This is why the insurance page in this book asks for it.
☐ Proof that you are the claimant	A beneficiary designation, a will, or a grant of probate — depending on the policy.
☐ Identity documents	Photo identification for the person claiming, and often proof of address.
☐ The claim form	Signed by the claimant, not by the estate, where a named beneficiary exists.
☐ Bank details	For the payout, in the name of the claimant.
☐ Anything else the policy requires	Some ask for medical information or a police report. Ask for the list in writing.

ONE CLAIM WORTH CHECKING FIRST

Where a policy names a beneficiary, the payout usually passes directly to that person and does not go through a court process at all. Where it does not, the money generally belongs to the estate and is dealt with by whoever is administering it. That single difference decides who fills in the form, and it is worth asking the insurer directly rather than guessing.

NOTES

PART 04

04

Wishes and preferences

What you would like to happen. This part is written in the first person on purpose: these are your words, and the person reading them should hear your voice, not a form's.

IN THIS PART

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Preference is not instruction

One distinction governs this entire part, and getting it right is the difference between helping your family and misleading them.

A preference is what you would like. An instruction is what the law will enforce. They can say the same thing, but only one of them is binding — and which is which depends on documents prepared and signed the way your state or country requires.

PREFERENCE	INSTRUCTION
"I would like my ashes scattered at the lake."	"My sister is to be the executor."
"Please don't have a big service."	"The house passes to my children equally."
"I want my daughter to have the piano."	"My share of the business transfers to my partner."
Recorded here, and acted on because your family chooses to honour it.	Recorded in a will, deed, beneficiary form or court filing — not here.

> **What this means in practice.** Write freely in this part. It is genuinely valuable — families overwhelmingly follow written wishes. But do not use it instead of a will, and do not use it to change one. If you want something to be binding, it has to be done the formal way, and page 55 lists the items that usually need that.

THREE THINGS WORTH KNOWING BEFORE YOU WRITE

- A will can generally be changed only by making another will, or by a formal amendment called a codicil. Writing a change in this book will not do it.
- Many financial accounts pass by beneficiary designation, which overrides what a will says. The name on the form is the one that counts.
- Requirements for witnessing, notarising and capacity differ between states. A document that is valid where it was signed may not be accepted elsewhere.

My healthcare wishes

Who speaks for me, and where the signed documents are. This page records names and locations — it is not a medical directive and carries no clinical instruction.

THE PERSON I WANT TO SPEAK FOR ME

RELATIONSHIP

PHONE

SECOND CHOICE, IF THEY CANNOT

MY DOCTOR

PHONE

WHERE MY SIGNED ADVANCE DIRECTIVE IS KEPT

WHO HOLDS A COPY

WHAT I HAVE ALREADY TOLD THE PEOPLE ABOVE

The most useful thing on this page is not a legal reference. It is a note saying that the conversation actually happened, so a family member does not have to wonder whether they are guessing.

> **Where the form itself goes.** A living will, healthcare power of attorney or advance directive is only useful if someone can produce it. Keep the signed original somewhere you can name, give a copy to the person named, and ask your doctor whether they want a copy for their file. Requirements for witnesses and notaries vary by state; the professional preparing the document will know.

NOTES

Funeral and disposition

The practical decisions, written down before anyone has to make them in a hurry and at a price.

BURIAL, CREMATION OR DONATION

☐ Burial ☐ Cremation ☐ Donation to science ☐ Already arranged

☐ Not sure — ask my family

IF BURIAL — CEMETERY OR PLOT

PLOT REFERENCE

IF CREMATION — WHAT SHOULD HAPPEN TO MY ASHES

WHO DECIDES

FUNERAL HOME, IF ALREADY CHOSEN

PHONE

IS A FUNERAL PLAN ALREADY PAID FOR?

PLAN REFERENCE

THE SERVICE

WHERE

WHO LEADS IT

MUSIC I WOULD LIKE

READINGS OR WORDS

WHO SHOULD SPEAK

WHO SHOULD NOT BE ASKED TO

FLOWERS, OR DONATIONS TO

CHARITY AND ADDRESS

ANYTHING ELSE THAT MATTERS TO ME

If you have prepaid a funeral plan, say so here and record where the paperwork is. A paid plan that nobody knows about is often paid for twice.

NOTES

Obituary worksheet

The facts a family would otherwise have to reconstruct from memory in the worst possible week. Fill in what you can; leave the rest.

FULL NAME

KNOWN AS

BORN — DATE

BORN — PLACE

PARENTS' NAMES

SCHOOLS AND COLLEGES

YEARS

CAREER — MAIN ROLES

EMPLOYERS

MILITARY SERVICE, IF ANY

BRANCH AND YEARS

MEMBERSHIPS, CLUBS, VOLUNTEERING

FAMILY TO BE NAMED

NAME	RELATIONSHIP	LIVING OR DECEASED

WHAT I WOULD LIKE SAID ABOUT ME

CHARITY FOR DONATIONS

WHERE TO SEND THEM

Personal belongings

The things you would like particular people to have. This is a record of wishes; it does not change a will, and it cannot.

> This page records what I would like. It does not transfer ownership of anything. If an item must go to a specific person by law, it needs to be named in your will.

ITEM	WHERE IT IS	WHO SHOULD HAVE IT	PROMISED?	IN MY WILL?

Start with the things people will actually argue about: jewellery, tools, instruments, photographs, furniture with a story attached.

> **The photographs problem.** Photographs and letters are the possessions most families fall out over and the ones least often mentioned in a will. If there is a set you care about, say here who should have it — and if it should be shared, say how, because 'they'll sort it out' rarely works.

Dependants and pets

For anyone who would be left in someone else's care. Write the routines down — the practical detail is what the person taking them on will thank you for.

PETS

NAME	KIND AND BREED	AGE	VET AND PHONE	WHO SHOULD CARE FOR THEM

FEEDING AND MEDICATION ROUTINE

INSURANCE POLICY

MICROCHIP NUMBER

REGISTERED TO

ANYTHING A NEW CARER MUST KNOW

DEPENDANTS

Whether arrangements for a dependant are legally binding depends on documents prepared properly — guardianship named in a will, a trust, or a court order. This page records your wishes and the practical detail; page 55 lists what needs a professional.

WHO I WOULD LIKE TO CARE FOR THEM

RELATIONSHIP

SECOND CHOICE

RELATIONSHIP

SCHOOL, DOCTOR AND DAILY ROUTINE

ANYTHING ELSE THE CARER MUST KNOW

Questions to discuss with family

The conversation is the point. These are prompts for it, and space to write what was said, so the next person does not have to ask again.

You do not have to answer these alone or in one sitting. The value is that the conversation happened and somebody wrote it down. If you would rather not write the answers, write the date you had the conversation and who was there — that alone prevents a great deal of guessing.

1 Is there anything you would want us to do, or not do, that we would not guess?

2 Who would you want making decisions if you could not? Have you asked them?

3 Which of these decisions would you rather we made together, than you alone?

4 Is there anything in this book you would rather certain people did not see?

5 Is there anyone you would want contacted that we might not think of?

6 What would you want us to do with your things that would feel wrong to guess at?

7 Is there anything you have been meaning to say to someone?

CONVERSATION HAD ON **WITH**

NOTES

What needs a professional

The items that cannot be done in a book, who usually prepares them, and the question worth asking before you pay anyone.

A will	An attorney in your state, or a service that supplies one. Two requirements are not optional: the witnesses your state requires, and the signature formalities. Ask who witnesses it and what happens if one of them cannot be found later.
A trust	An attorney. A trust is a legal structure with tax and reporting consequences, and a badly drafted one is worse than none. Ask what has to be transferred into it, because an empty trust does nothing.
Power of attorney — finances	An attorney, or a form provided by your state. Ask which powers it grants, when it starts, and whether your state requires a notary or witnesses.
Healthcare directive	Often a state form, sometimes completed with your doctor. Ask whether your state requires witnesses, a notary, or both, and whether your doctor will keep a copy.
Guardianship of a minor	Normally named in a will, prepared by an attorney. Ask what the court will require, because a named guardian may still need court approval.
Beneficiary designations	The institution holding the account, on their own form. Ask for a copy of the completed form and keep it with the account record — this is the document that usually overrides the will.
Property and titles	An attorney, a title company or the county recorder. Ask how the property is currently held, because that determines what happens next.

> **One question that saves money.** If you are paying someone to prepare documents, ask two things: which of these do I actually need for my situation, and what will it cost in total including filing fees. Both are fair questions, and the answers belong in the change log at the back.

This book can record that each document exists and where the signed original is kept, and that is genuinely useful. It cannot create any of them, and no amount of careful writing here makes one binding.

People I would like told in person

Not a notification list — the handful of people who should hear it from someone, not read it.

A death reaches a wide circle quickly and unevenly. This page names the people for whom the manner of hearing it matters, and who should be the one to tell them.

NAME	RELATIONSHIP	WHO SHOULD TELL THEM	ANYTHING TO SAY FIRST

ANYONE WHO SHOULD BE TOLD BEFORE THE NEWS SPREADS

If there is someone you would rather were told kindly, by a particular person, this is the page that makes that possible. It is a small thing to write and it is worth a great deal later.

NOTES

The order of service

The shape of the day itself, written down. Nobody has to follow it — but having something to follow is a kindness to whoever is organising it.

WHERE

DATE AND TIME

WHO LEADS

APPROXIMATE LENGTH

RUNNING ORDER

1 Music as people arrive

2 Opening words

3 Reading or poem

4 Music or a song

5 Remembrance — who speaks

6 Reading or poem

7 Closing words

8 Music as people leave

MUSIC AND READINGS

FIRST PIECE

WHO PLAYS IT

SECOND PIECE

WHO PLAYS IT

READING I WOULD LIKE, AND WHO SHOULD READ IT

WHAT I WOULD RATHER WAS LEFT OUT

NOTES

If there is no will

A page for the reader who has not made one, is not sure, or is putting it off. It is written to be useful rather than alarming.

Dying without a valid will is called dying intestate. What happens then is decided by the law of the state where you live, not by what anyone remembers you saying. The rules are specific and they are not intuitive — in many places a spouse does not automatically receive everything, and an unmarried partner usually receives nothing at all.

This book cannot tell you what those rules are for your situation. It can do two things: record whether you have a will, and give you the questions worth asking before you pay anyone to make one.

THE HONEST POSITION, TODAY

I HAVE A SIGNED WILL, AND I KNOW WHERE THE ORIGINAL IS	☐ Yes	☐ No	☐ Not sure
IT WAS REVIEWED IN THE LAST FIVE YEARS	☐ Yes	☐ No	☐ Not sure
THE PEOPLE NAMED IN IT ARE STILL THE RIGHT PEOPLE	☐ Yes	☐ No	☐ Not sure
I HAVE TOLD SOMEONE WHERE THE ORIGINAL IS KEPT	☐ Yes	☐ No	

QUESTIONS WORTH ASKING BEFORE YOU PAY FOR ONE

- ☐ Do I need a will, or would a beneficiary designation do the job?
- ☐ Who will act for my estate, and have I asked them?
- ☐ If I have children, who should care for them, and does that need a court's approval?
- ☐ Does my state require witnesses, a notary, or both?
- ☐ Where should the signed original be kept, and who else will know?
- ☐ What will this cost in total, including any filing fee?

One thing this page will not do is reassure you that a note in a book is enough. It is not, and no amount of careful writing here changes that.

NOTES

Things I would like kept together

Not the valuable things — the ones that only make sense as a group. Photographs, letters, a recipe book, a box of postcards.

Objects like these are the ones most often lost, not because nobody wanted them but because they were split up before anyone realised they belonged together. A sentence here prevents that, and it is the kind of sentence only you can write.

THE SET OR GROUP	WHERE IT IS NOW	WHO SHOULD HAVE IT	OR WHO DECIDES

WHAT SHOULD HAPPEN TO THE REST

It helps to say what may be thrown away. Families keep far too much for fear of discarding something that mattered, and a line saying 'the furniture in the back room can go' is a genuine kindness.

NOTES

Organ and tissue donation

A page of facts and a place to record a decision, because this is the one question where a family is often asked to guess.

In many countries donation is decided by a register, and in some it is presumed unless a person opted out. Whether a family is consulted, and how much weight their view carries, differs by country and often by state. The one thing that is consistent is that a family who know what the person wanted find the conversation far easier.

I HAVE REGISTERED AS A DONOR ☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure

MY FAMILY KNOWS WHAT I DECIDED ☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure

I WOULD WANT MY FAMILY TO BE ASKED FIRST ☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure

THE REGISTER OR RECORD I AM ON

CHECKED ON

WHERE THAT REGISTRATION IS RECORDED

ANYTHING I WOULD WANT SAID TO MY FAMILY ABOUT THIS

> **What this page is not.** It is not a consent form, and it does not override a register. It records what you decided and where the record lives, so that a family asked to decide at a hospital desk has something better than a guess.

NOTES

PART 05

05

Digital assets

The part of an estate that did not exist thirty years ago. Nothing here asks you to write a secret. Everything here asks you to write a location.

IN THIS PART

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Why this part is different

A house can be found. A photograph library cannot, if nobody knows it exists.

Most of what a person owns today leaves no physical trace. There is no drawer to open, no envelope to find, no key on a hook. There is an account behind a sign-in that only one person has ever used, and the family has to guess that it exists at all.

That has three consequences this part is built around.

Nobody can search for what they cannot name

So the inventory on page 64 lists services by name, with room to write the ones this book did not think of. That is the difference between a checklist and an inventory.

Ownership is not the same as access

A purchased film, an ebook library, a domain name and a currency balance are held on very different terms. This book records what each thing is for and what should happen to it, which is what a family needs.

Some things should be closed, and some should not

A photo library is worth keeping. A subscription is worth cancelling. An account full of messages may be worth memorialising rather than deleting. Deciding that in advance is a gift, not a chore.

> **A word about what is not recorded.** There is no page in this part for a password, a PIN, a recovery phrase, a private key or a one-time code, and there never will be. What is recorded is where each of those is held and who can reach it. That is the only version of this book that is safe to keep in a house.

NOTES

The one rule

Record the location, never the thing itself. The rest of the design follows from that.

> **DO NOT WRITE IN THIS BOOK**
>
> - a password or PIN
> - a recovery phrase or seed phrase
> - a private key, backup code or one-time code
> - an answer to a security question

This is not caution for its own sake. A book on a shelf is not a vault. It can be left on a train, photographed by a visitor, read by a relative who was not meant to see it, or sold in a house clearance. Anything written in it should be safe to read aloud.

WHAT TO RECORD INSTEAD

Instead of the password	Which password manager holds it, and where that manager's recovery kit is kept.
Instead of the recovery phrase	That a recovery phrase exists, and which sealed envelope or safe it is in — never the words themselves.
Instead of security answers	The method you use for them, so a family knows they exist and knows not to guess.
Instead of the two-factor codes	Which device or app receives them, and who else can reach that device.

The left column is what people write and should not. The middle column is what this book asks for, and it is genuinely enough: a family that knows a password manager exists, who administers it, and where its recovery kit is kept can get into everything, without ever being handed a list of secrets.

> **If you have already written secrets somewhere.** Do not panic, and do not simply throw the book away — you would lose the locations too. Move the secrets into a password manager, then destroy the page. If the page was photographed or scanned, delete the image and empty the bin. Part one covers where a password manager's own recovery kit belongs, and it is not in this book.

Account and service inventory

One band per service. Work from the app list on your phone and a recent bank statement — between them they will surface almost everything.

Sheet 1 of 3. If you need more bands, tick the box at the foot of this page.

REF D1

SERVICE OR ACCOUNT — FOR EXAMPLE A PHOTO SERVICE, A BANK APP, A SUBSCRIPTION

WHAT MY FAMILY NEEDS IT FOR | **RECORDED IN THE LOCATOR AS** | **OR HELD BY**

SIGN-IN DETAILS HELD WHERE — TICK ONE, NEVER THE VALUE

☐ Password manager ☐ Sealed envelope ☐ With my attorney ☐ Other, not in this book

NEXT-OF-KIN OR LEGACY SETTING IN THE SERVICE?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure

REF D2

SERVICE OR ACCOUNT — FOR EXAMPLE A PHOTO SERVICE, A BANK APP, A SUBSCRIPTION

WHAT MY FAMILY NEEDS IT FOR | **RECORDED IN THE LOCATOR AS** | **OR HELD BY**

SIGN-IN DETAILS HELD WHERE — TICK ONE, NEVER THE VALUE

☐ Password manager ☐ Sealed envelope ☐ With my attorney ☐ Other, not in this book

NEXT-OF-KIN OR LEGACY SETTING IN THE SERVICE?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure

REF D3

SERVICE OR ACCOUNT — FOR EXAMPLE A PHOTO SERVICE, A BANK APP, A SUBSCRIPTION

WHAT MY FAMILY NEEDS IT FOR | **RECORDED IN THE LOCATOR AS** | **OR HELD BY**

SIGN-IN DETAILS HELD WHERE — TICK ONE, NEVER THE VALUE

☐ Password manager ☐ Sealed envelope ☐ With my attorney ☐ Other, not in this book

NEXT-OF-KIN OR LEGACY SETTING IN THE SERVICE?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure

☐ **I HAVE MORE ACCOUNTS THAN THERE ARE BANDS IN THIS PART**

I CONTINUED ON A SEPARATE SHEET, DATED | **NUMBER OF ENTRIES RECORDED HERE**

NOTES

Account and service inventory

Sheet 2 of 3. If you need more bands, tick the box at the foot of this page.

REF D4

SERVICE OR ACCOUNT — FOR EXAMPLE A PHOTO SERVICE, A BANK APP, A SUBSCRIPTION

WHAT MY FAMILY NEEDS IT FOR | **RECORDED IN THE LOCATOR AS** | **OR HELD BY**

SIGN-IN DETAILS HELD WHERE — TICK ONE, NEVER THE VALUE

☐ Password manager ☐ Sealed envelope ☐ With my attorney ☐ Other, not in this book

NEXT-OF-KIN OR LEGACY SETTING IN THE SERVICE?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure

REF D5

SERVICE OR ACCOUNT — FOR EXAMPLE A PHOTO SERVICE, A BANK APP, A SUBSCRIPTION

WHAT MY FAMILY NEEDS IT FOR | **RECORDED IN THE LOCATOR AS** | **OR HELD BY**

SIGN-IN DETAILS HELD WHERE — TICK ONE, NEVER THE VALUE

☐ Password manager ☐ Sealed envelope ☐ With my attorney ☐ Other, not in this book

NEXT-OF-KIN OR LEGACY SETTING IN THE SERVICE?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure

REF D6

SERVICE OR ACCOUNT — FOR EXAMPLE A PHOTO SERVICE, A BANK APP, A SUBSCRIPTION

WHAT MY FAMILY NEEDS IT FOR | **RECORDED IN THE LOCATOR AS** | **OR HELD BY**

SIGN-IN DETAILS HELD WHERE — TICK ONE, NEVER THE VALUE

☐ Password manager ☐ Sealed envelope ☐ With my attorney ☐ Other, not in this book

NEXT-OF-KIN OR LEGACY SETTING IN THE SERVICE?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure

☐ **I HAVE MORE ACCOUNTS THAN THERE ARE BANDS IN THIS PART**

I CONTINUED ON A SEPARATE SHEET, DATED | **NUMBER OF ENTRIES RECORDED HERE**

NOTES

Account and service inventory

Sheet 3 of 3. If you need more bands, tick the box at the foot of this page.

REF D7

SERVICE OR ACCOUNT — FOR EXAMPLE A PHOTO SERVICE, A BANK APP, A SUBSCRIPTION

WHAT MY FAMILY NEEDS IT FOR | **RECORDED IN THE LOCATOR AS** | **OR HELD BY**

SIGN-IN DETAILS HELD WHERE — TICK ONE, NEVER THE VALUE

☐ Password manager ☐ Sealed envelope ☐ With my attorney ☐ Other, not in this book

NEXT-OF-KIN OR LEGACY SETTING IN THE SERVICE?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure

REF D8

SERVICE OR ACCOUNT — FOR EXAMPLE A PHOTO SERVICE, A BANK APP, A SUBSCRIPTION

WHAT MY FAMILY NEEDS IT FOR | **RECORDED IN THE LOCATOR AS** | **OR HELD BY**

SIGN-IN DETAILS HELD WHERE — TICK ONE, NEVER THE VALUE

☐ Password manager ☐ Sealed envelope ☐ With my attorney ☐ Other, not in this book

NEXT-OF-KIN OR LEGACY SETTING IN THE SERVICE?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure

REF D9

SERVICE OR ACCOUNT — FOR EXAMPLE A PHOTO SERVICE, A BANK APP, A SUBSCRIPTION

WHAT MY FAMILY NEEDS IT FOR | **RECORDED IN THE LOCATOR AS** | **OR HELD BY**

SIGN-IN DETAILS HELD WHERE — TICK ONE, NEVER THE VALUE

☐ Password manager ☐ Sealed envelope ☐ With my attorney ☐ Other, not in this book

NEXT-OF-KIN OR LEGACY SETTING IN THE SERVICE?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure

☐ **I HAVE MORE ACCOUNTS THAN THERE ARE BANDS IN THIS PART**

I CONTINUED ON A SEPARATE SHEET, DATED | **NUMBER OF ENTRIES RECORDED HERE**

NOTES

Legacy and next-of-kin settings

Some services let you nominate someone in advance. The settings change often, so this book asks you the question rather than telling you the answer.

Several large services now offer a way to name a contact, or to decide in advance what happens to an account. The names of these features, and which services offer them, change from year to year — so writing them down here would be wrong within a year. Instead, this page records the state of yours, as you find it.

SERVICE	HAS A SETTING?	WHO I HAVE NAMED	CHECKED ON	WHERE I FOUND IT

Look under account settings, privacy, or help. Searching the service name plus 'what happens to my account' usually finds it in a minute.

> **Why this is worth ten minutes per service.** Where a service offers this, naming someone is the difference between a family being able to download years of photographs and being permanently locked out. Where it offers nothing, the family at least knows not to waste weeks trying.

Where my digital documents live

The scans, the photographs and the files that would be genuinely hard to replace.

WHAT IT IS	ACCOUNT OR SERVICE	WHICH FOLDER	WHO ELSE CAN OPEN IT

Include the things that are not obviously 'documents': the family photo archive, scanned certificates, the folder of tax returns.

If a folder is shared with anyone, say so here. If it is not shared, say that too — 'nobody else can see this' is exactly the fact a family needs and exactly the fact nobody writes down.

ANYTHING IN THESE FOLDERS THAT MATTERS MORE THAN THE REST

NOTES

Password manager and recovery kit

The single most useful page in this part — and the one where you write the least.

If you use a password manager, almost everything a family needs is behind one door. This page records which door it is, who administers it, and where the emergency access or recovery kit is kept. It does not record anything that would open it.

I USE A PASSWORD MANAGER

WHICH ONE

THE ACCOUNT IS REGISTERED TO

EMAIL ON THE ACCOUNT

FAMILY OR EMERGENCY ACCESS IS SET UP?

WHO IS NAMED

WHERE THE RECOVERY KIT OR EMERGENCY SHEET IS KEPT — BE SPECIFIC

WHO ELSE KNOWS IT IS THERE

IF I DO NOT USE A PASSWORD MANAGER, WHERE ARE SIGN-INS KEPT INSTEAD

> **The one paper that must not be in this book.** Most password managers issue a recovery kit or emergency sheet when you set them up. It usually contains the only thing that could unlock everything else. Keep it somewhere physically separate from this book, and make sure a second person knows where that place is — otherwise the kit is just another secret nobody can find.

IF THERE IS NO PASSWORD MANAGER

Then the sign-ins are wherever they are, and the useful thing to record is the method, not the secrets: the notebook kept in a drawer, the browser's saved passwords on a particular device, the one person who resets them all. Write that on the line above in plain words. A family following a described method can work things out; a family facing a locked device cannot.

NOTES

Security questions

The weakest link in most accounts, and the one thing people are most tempted to write down. Here is how to handle it without writing the answer.

Security questions usually ask for facts that are permanent, guessable, and often publicly available — a mother's maiden name, a first school, a first pet. That makes them a poor lock. It also makes them a poor thing to record in a book, because the answer is the secret.

THREE APPROACHES THAT WORK

1. Use a nonsense answer

   Answer every security question with an unrelated phrase, stored in your password manager like any other password. Note here that you do this — not what the answers are.

2. Use the manager's notes field

   Most password managers have a notes field per entry. That is the right place for a security answer, protected by the manager rather than by a shelf.

3. Remove the question where you can

   Many services let you switch to a second factor such as an authenticator app instead. That is both safer and easier to hand over.

WHAT I DO

MY METHOD FOR SECURITY QUESTIONS	RECORDED IN MY MANAGER?

ACCOUNTS WHERE I HAVE REMOVED THE QUESTION AND USE A SECOND FACTOR INSTEAD

If any of the answers you currently use are things a family member could find out — a surname, a school, a street — that is worth changing rather than recording. It is a ten-minute job and it removes the one part of account security that a well-meaning relative could otherwise guess.

NOTES

Keep, close or memorialise

A decision per account, made now rather than guessed later. Most problems here come from an absence of instructions, not from a difficult choice.

ACCOUNT OR SERVICE	KEEP OPEN	DOWNLOAD	MEMORIALISE	CLOSE	NOTES

A helpful default: anything with photographs or writing in it should be downloaded before it is closed.

How each of these is done is a question for the service itself, and the answer changes. What this page fixes is your intention, so a family member does not have to decide what you would have wanted while also learning where to click.

Recurring digital charges

The quiet ones. A card can keep paying a subscription for months after a death, and nobody notices until the statement is read.

SERVICE	WHAT IT IS FOR	PAID FROM	RENEWS	CANCEL	KEEP

Check the app store subscriptions on a phone as well as the bank statement. Store billing is easy to miss.

> **Where these hide.** Three places catch most of them: the recurring payments list on each bank account, the subscriptions page in each app store, and the payment methods page inside the services themselves. Between the three, almost everything surfaces.

Digital review dates

Digital records go out of date faster than anything else in this book. This page turns that into a small habit rather than a worry.

Two years is a reasonable interval for a full pass through this part: long enough not to be tedious, short enough that a closed account or an abandoned service has not had time to disappear entirely. Anything that involves money or photographs is worth checking annually.

WHAT I REVIEWED	DATE	WHAT CHANGED	INITIALS

NEXT FULL REVIEW DUE

REMINDER SET WHERE

Write the reminder somewhere you will actually see it — a calendar entry, a note on the inside of a cupboard door, the same place you keep your passport. A review page nobody remembers to revisit is the most common way a good organizer quietly becomes wrong.

NOTES

Devices, drives and backups

The physical half of a digital life. A phone in a drawer can hold more of a person than a filing cabinet, and it is the object most likely to be locked.

DEVICE	WHERE IT IS	WHAT IS ON IT	LOCKED HOW	WHO CAN UNLOCK IT

Phone, laptop, tablet, desktop, external drive, camera card, NAS, smartwatch. 'Locked how' means the method, never the value.

BACKUPS

WHERE THE MAIN BACKUP LIVES

HOW OFTEN IT RUNS

SECOND COPY, IF ANY

WHERE THAT COPY IS

BACKUP PASSWORD OR KEY HELD WHERE

ACCOUNT IT BELONGS TO

> **The one thing worth doing today.** If a phone or laptop holds photographs nobody has copied, copy them. An archive that exists on one device exists zero times, and a locked device is not a record — it is a locked box with no key on this page.

Things bought and licensed

Digital purchases usually cannot be inherited — they are licensed, not owned. That makes them worth listing precisely because a family will otherwise assume they can simply be passed on.

A film bought from a store, an ebook library, a music collection, a piece of software and a domain name are held on very different terms. Some can be transferred, some cannot, and some have a formal process for it. This page records what exists and what you would like to happen to it; the terms themselves are the service's to state.

WHAT IT IS	WHERE IT LIVES	ACCOUNT	TRANSFER?	WHAT I WOULD LIKE

Include domain names, website hosting, software licences, marketplace seller accounts, and subscriptions with a paid balance.

ANYTHING HERE THAT IS WORTH REAL MONEY

WHERE THE PROOF OF PURCHASE IS

Where a service offers a way to nominate someone, use it and note it in the legacy table on page 67. Where it does not, writing your intention here still tells a family whether to spend an afternoon trying.

NOTES

Email, messaging and social accounts

The accounts that hold the correspondence. They are also the keys to everything else, because almost every other service sends its password reset to one of them.

That last point is why this page comes before the password manager page. An email account is not just a mailbox; it is the recovery route for a dozen others. What a family needs to know is which address is the primary one, who administers it, and whether a second person could get into it.

SERVICE	ADDRESS OR HANDLE	PRIMARY?	WHAT IT UNLOCKS	HANDLING

Handling: keep open, download and close, memorialise, delete. Note that a memorialised account often cannot be logged into at all.

THE ADDRESS MOST THINGS ARE REGISTERED TO

WHO ELSE CAN ACCESS IT

> **Why the primary address matters more than the rest.** A family who can reach that address can usually recover the rest through ordinary account recovery, without anyone writing a password down.

Digital money and marketplaces

Wallets, payment apps, trading accounts and seller accounts. Small balances, large consequences: money in an app is easy to overlook and hard to claim.

SERVICE	WHAT IT IS FOR	HELD BY	LINKED TO	APPROX. BALANCE

Payment apps, digital wallets, trading and crypto accounts, marketplace seller accounts, loyalty balances with a cash value.

WHAT A FAMILY WOULD NEED

Unlike a bank account, these usually have no branch and no named contact, and their process for a death is often handled entirely inside the app. The two facts that help most are which email address the account is registered to, and whether a second person is named on it.

EMAIL THESE ARE REGISTERED TO

SECOND PERSON NAMED ON ANY

WHERE THE RECOVERY OR SECURITY SETTINGS FOR THESE ARE DOCUMENTED

Nothing on this page asks for a balance to the penny, a wallet address or a key. An approximate figure tells a family whether it is worth pursuing, which is the only question this book can answer.

Home network and smart devices

The router, the hub, the cameras and the thermostat. A modern house has a dozen accounts inside it and no paperwork to match.

These matter for two reasons. Some of them hold recordings or a record of who came and went, which a family may want. All of them hold an account, and an account nobody can reach is a device nobody can reset — which for a smart lock or an alarm is more than an inconvenience.

DEVICE OR SYSTEM	WHO SUPPLIES IT	ACCOUNT REGISTERED TO	APP ON WHOSE PHONE

Router and internet, alarm and cameras, doorbell, heating, locks, solar or battery system, car charging, irrigation.

BROADBAND CONTRACT AND ACCOUNT HOLDER

ENDS OR RENEWS

WHERE THE ROUTER AND ITS LABEL ARE

NETWORK NAME, IF UNUSUAL

ANYTHING RECORDED BY THESE DEVICES THAT A FAMILY MAY WANT KEPT

The network name is not a secret. The password is, and it belongs in the password manager with everything else — not here.

Digital accounts in the first two weeks

The order in which to work through a digital life, if you are the one doing it. The sequence matters more than the speed.

The instinct is to close everything at once. That is usually the wrong first move, because the most valuable things in a digital life — photographs, letters, a record of where money went — sit behind the accounts that are easiest to cancel. Work in this order.

1 Download before you change anything

Photographs, documents, message archives, purchase histories. Every large service has an export or download option; use it first, while access still works normally.

2 Secure the primary email

It is the recovery route for everything else. Do not close it. Keep it reachable and note who can get into it.

3 List before you close

One pass through the bank statement and the app store finds almost every recurring charge. Cancel subscriptions only after that list exists.

4 Change nothing that a will or a policy refers to

An account named in a beneficiary designation is part of an estate, not clutter. Ask before closing it.

5 Then deal with the accounts nobody needs

Social accounts, shopping accounts, loyalty schemes. Slow, low-value, and safe to leave until the important things are done.

WHAT I WOULD WANT DONE FIRST

THE ONE FOLDER, ALBUM OR ARCHIVE THAT MATTERS MOST

WHO SHOULD DOWNLOAD IT

WHERE IT SHOULD GO

Naming one thing is more useful than naming ten.

PART 06

06

The document locator

One table, forty categories, one question per row: where is it. Everything else in this book points here, which means this is the part you fill in first and revisit most.

IN THIS PART

How the locator works 81
Locator — sheet 1 82
Locator — sheet 2 83
Locator — sheet 3 84
Locator — sheet 4 85
If a document is missing 86
Locator — sheet 5 87
Locator — sheet 6 88
The first hour with this book 89

How the locator works

Five columns, and one rule: a location, never a value.

REF	A short code, so other pages can point at a row without writing the whole name.
DOCUMENT	What it is. Pre-printed, so you are prompted rather than remembering.
WHERE IT IS HELD	The room, the box, the drawer, the folder. Specific enough that a person who has never been in your house could find it.
WHO ELSE KNOWS	The name of a person or a professional. This column is why the table works when you are not there.
VERIFIED ON	The date you last confirmed the row still points at something real. A stale date is a warning, not a failure.

> **Fill in the rows you cannot answer as 'none' or 'missing'.** A row that says 'I do not have this' is more useful than a blank row, because it tells a family whether to look for it or to replace it. Part six ends with where to get each one replaced.

Do not write account numbers, policy numbers or digits in the locator. It answers 'where', not 'which one exactly' — the record pages in Parts three and five carry those, and a family can find them once they know where the original is kept.

NOTES

The locator

Ten rows per page. Work steadily; there is no prize for finishing the table in one sitting.

Sheet 1 of 4

REF	DOCUMENT	WHERE IT IS HELD	WHO ELSE KNOWS	VERIFIED ON
	Passport			
	Driver licence or state ID			
	Birth certificate			
	Social Security card			
	Marriage certificate			
	Divorce or separation papers			
	Adoption papers			
	Naturalisation or citizenship certificate			
	Military discharge (DD-214)			
	Professional or trade licence			

NOTES

The locator

Sheet 2 of 4

REF	DOCUMENT	WHERE IT IS HELD	WHO ELSE KNOWS	VERIFIED ON
	Will — signed original			
	Trust documents			
	Power of attorney — finances			
	Healthcare power of attorney			
	Advance directive or living will			
	Property deed			
	Mortgage or loan agreement			
	Vehicle title			
	Lease or tenancy agreement			
	Business formation documents			

NOTES

The locator

Sheet 3 of 4

REF	DOCUMENT	WHERE IT IS HELD	WHO ELSE KNOWS	VERIFIED ON
	Life insurance policy			
	Other insurance policies			
	Pension and retirement statements			
	Tax returns — last three years			
	Bank and account statements			
	Investment and brokerage records			
	Loan and credit agreements			
	Employment contract and benefits			
	Medical records and medication list			
	Vaccination and immunisation records			

NOTES

The locator

Sheet 4 of 4

REF	DOCUMENT	WHERE IT IS HELD	WHO ELSE KNOWS	VERIFIED ON
	Photograph and family archive			
	Password manager recovery kit			
	Safe, lockbox or deposit box			
	Keys and access cards			
	Vehicle registration			
	Pet records and microchip papers			
	Warranties and receipts			
	Memberships and season tickets			
	Subscriptions and renewals			
	Anything else that has no obvious home			

NOTES

If a document is missing

Where each one is replaced. These are the official routes, and they are free to look up.

Birth, death, marriage, divorce	The state or territory where the event happened — never the federal government. The CDC publishes a directory of every issuing office, and most states accept requests online.
Passport	The State Department, for a new or replacement passport. A passport belonging to someone who has died is returned to the State Department for cancellation, which also reduces the risk of identity theft.
Social Security card	The Social Security Administration. A replacement card is free, and there are limits on how many you can get in a year.
Driver licence	Your state licensing agency. If the licence was lost, the agency can usually confirm the details even if a replacement is not needed.
Military discharge	The National Archives, for a DD-214 or equivalent. Veterans' service organisations can often help with the request at no cost.
Property deed	The county recorder or land registry where the property is. Deeds are public records, so a copy is usually obtainable without the original.
Vehicle title	Your state motor vehicle agency. A duplicate title usually requires an application and a fee, and the rules differ by state.
A will	Nobody reissues a will. If the original cannot be found, the attorney who prepared it, or the court where it was filed, is the place to start.

Birth, death, marriage and divorce records are held by the state or territory where the event happened, not by the federal government — the CDC publishes a directory of every issuing office. Death certificates are usually ordered through the funeral home, or directly from the local department of health if there is no funeral home involved.

Some records release only to certain family members, and some become public after a set number of years that differs by state. If a request is refused, ask the issuing office why rather than assuming.

The locator

Sheet 5 of 6

REF	DOCUMENT	WHERE IT IS HELD	WHO ELSE KNOWS	VERIFIED ON
	Account statements — last 12 months			
	Loan and credit agreements			
	Pension and retirement statements			
	Beneficiary designation forms			
	Tax returns and notices			
	Business accounts and filings			
	Trust deeds and amendments			
	Court orders and settlements			
	Immigration and visa documents			
	Custody or guardianship orders			

NOTES

The locator

Sheet 6 of 6

REF	DOCUMENT	WHERE IT IS HELD	WHO ELSE KNOWS	VERIFIED ON
	Medication list and prescriptions			
	Immunisation and vaccination records			
	Hospital and specialist reports			
	Dental records			
	Optician and hearing records			
	Insurance claim files			
	Correspondence with a professional			
	Anything I have not been able to place			
	Anything a family should not open alone			
	Anything that needs a password to read			

If you still need rows, write the document name on a sheet of paper, number it 'L' with the next number in this series, and keep it folded inside the back cover. The series is what makes the cross-references in the rest of the book work, not the paper it is printed on.

NOTES

The first hour with this book

For the person who has just been handed it. Four places to look, in this order, and nothing else to read yet.

You do not need to read this book. You need about six facts, and they are all on four pages. Take them one at a time, and stop when you have what you came for.

1 The first 48 hours page 18

What to do today, in order, and what can wait.

2 The one-page summary page 15

Names, phone numbers, and where the originals are kept.

3 The document locator page 82

Where every document is, and who else knows it exists.

4 Who to notify page 21

The list of organisations, and what each one needs.

> **If the book is not where it should be.** Ask the person named on page 10, then the second person. Both names are on the same page, and one of them will know. This is the reason the second name exists at all.

Nothing in this book asks you to make a decision you are not ready to make. Where a decision cannot wait, the page says so. Where it can, the page says that too.

NOTES

PART 07

07

Maintenance

A record that is never updated stops being true. This part is deliberately short: one annual pass, one change log, one conversation.

IN THIS PART

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Telling your trusted person	96
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A family conversation, with an agenda	98
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The annual review

Ten minutes, once a year, on a date you choose. That is the whole maintenance plan.

Pick a date you already notice — a birthday, a renewal, the first cold week of the year. The date matters less than the fact that it is a date rather than an intention.

	DATE
☐ Open the Document Locator and check each row still points at something real.	
☐ Update any row whose document has moved, been replaced, or been lost.	
☐ Check the 'who else knows' column — has anyone moved, died or become unreachable?	
☐ Open Part five and check for accounts you have closed or services you have started.	
☐ Check that no subscription is still being paid for something you no longer use.	
☐ Confirm the password manager still exists and the recovery kit is where you wrote that it is.	
☐ Check that your trusted person is still the right person, and still reachable.	
☐ Re-read Part four. Does it still say what you mean?	
☐ Enter the date on the review record overleaf.	
☐ Tell your trusted person that you have reviewed it.	

> **If you do nothing else.** Check the trusted person's phone number and the location of the book. Those two facts are the difference between a record that gets used and a record that is never found. Everything else on this list can wait a year.

NOTES

Review record

One line per year. Signing this is a promise to a person, not a formality.

DATE REVIEWED	WHAT CHANGED	TOLD WHOM	NEXT DUE

NOTES

Review record

DATE REVIEWED	WHAT CHANGED	TOLD WHOM	NEXT DUE

NOTES

Change log

The pages that stop you relying on memory. Write the change the day you make it — a house move, a closed account, a new policy.

DATE	PAGE OR PART	WHAT CHANGED	WHO I TOLD	INITIALS
NOTES				

Change log

DATE	PAGE OR PART	WHAT CHANGED	WHO I TOLD	INITIALS
NOTES				

Telling your trusted person

A short script, so the conversation is easy to start. Say it once a year; it takes two minutes.

Most people put this off because it feels like a conversation about death. It is really a conversation about a book and a drawer. Framed that way, it is unremarkable — and the second time you have it, it takes seconds.

WHAT TO SAY

THE BOOK EXISTS	"I have written something down — where the documents are, the accounts, who to call. It is in a book, and I want you to know it exists."
WHERE IT IS	"It is kept in the [room], in the [place]. If you ever need it, that is where it is."
WHAT IT DOES NOT CONTAIN	"There are no passwords in it, on purpose. It tells you where things are kept, not how to open them."
WHO ELSE KNOWS	"[Name] knows as well. If you cannot reach me, ask them."
WHAT YOU WANT THEM TO DO	"If something happens, read the section called The First 48 Hours first. The rest can wait."

CONVERSATION HAD ON _____ **WITH** _____

WHAT THEY ASKED ME, AND WHAT I PROMISED TO CHANGE

If they asked a question you could not answer, write it on that line and answer it next time. That single habit is what keeps this book honest.

NOTES

If your circumstances change

Six events make a records organizer wrong quickly. None of them require you to redo the whole book.

Each of these changes a specific set of pages. Fixing them the week they happen takes less time than reconstructing them in five years.

You move house

Locator locations, the 'where the originals live' page, the book's own location, insurance and property pages. Tell your trusted person the new room and shelf.

A marriage, divorce or death in the family

Beneficiary names, next of kin, the people-to-notify pages, and anything in Part four that named a person. Beneficiary designations usually need the institution, not this book.

You change job or retire

Employment and benefits, pension details, death-in-service cover, and any life insurance that came with the job.

You open or close an account

The financial pages, the digital inventory and the recurring charges list. Closing an account without updating the book is the most common way these pages go stale.

A named person dies or becomes unreachable

Every page naming them: trusted person, executor, attorney, next of kin, guardian. This one matters most, and it is the easiest to overlook.

You make a new will or directive

Locator row, the professional who prepared it, and anything in Part four that has now become binding. Note the date you signed it.

> **The five-minute habit.** When you make any change to a document, a bank account or a person named in this book, turn to the change log and write one line before you put the pen down. That is the entire maintenance system, and it is enough.

A family conversation, with an agenda

One hour, once. Not a crisis meeting — a short one where the book is opened in front of the people it is for.

Most families never do this, and the ones who do almost never regret it. The point is not to discuss death. It is to make sure two people can find one book and know what is in it. An agenda makes that easy to start and, more importantly, easy to finish.

1	Where the book is	Open it. Show them. Then put it back.
2	The one-page summary	Read it aloud. It takes a minute.
3	Who the trusted person is	And the second name, if the first is unreachable.
4	Where the documents are	The physical place, and the digital folder.
5	What this book does not contain	No passwords. Say this out loud.
6	Who else should know	Anyone not in the room who should be told the book exists.
7	What is missing	The gaps you both noticed. Write them in the change log.
8	When you will do this again	A date, not an intention.

WHAT WAS SAID

PRESENT

DATE

If the conversation went badly, that is worth writing down too. A family that disagreed about something in 2026 will not be surprised by it in 2031, and the note is what makes that possible.

NOTES

If I cannot manage this myself

A page for the possibility that the person who keeps this book becomes unable to. It records who else can act, not what they should decide.

A power of attorney is a legal document, and this book cannot create one. What it can do is record that one exists, who holds it, where the original is, and when it was signed — which is exactly what a bank or a hospital will ask for when it is produced.

FINANCIAL POWER OF ATTORNEY — HOLDER

SIGNED ON

WHERE THE SIGNED ORIGINAL IS

COPY HELD BY

HEALTHCARE PROXY OR ATTORNEY

SIGNED ON

WHERE THAT ORIGINAL IS

COPY HELD BY

ANY RESTRICTION ON WHEN IT TAKES EFFECT

DOCUMENTED WHERE

WHAT THIS BOOK WOULD NEED FROM SOMEONE ELSE

If the book has to be maintained by another person for a while, three things make that possible: they know where it is, they know which parts are current, and they know who to ask before changing anything. That is the whole handover.

WHO COULD MAINTAIN IT IF I COULD NOT

THEY KNOW?

WHAT THEY SHOULD NOT CHANGE WITHOUT ASKING

Requirements for powers of attorney vary widely between states, including whether they must be witnessed, notarised, or renewed. The professional who prepared yours will know; this page only records it.

NOTES

PART 08

08

Notes and letters

Two kinds of writing. One is for the practical things that have no form — the notes, the questions, the things you keep meaning to mention. The other is for the people you would want to hear from you.

IN THIS PART

How to write these pages	101
Notes and things to remember	102
Letters	103
Notes	107
A letter to whoever settles my estate	109

How to write these pages

There is no right way to do this, and nothing here is graded. A short, awkward, honest note is worth more than a formal one.

If you have never written a letter like this, the blank page is the enemy rather than the writing. Four things help.

1. Write to one person

   Not to "my family". One name at the top, and write as though they are in the room.

2. Say the small things

   The phrase you always used, the thing you argued about, the song. Specific detail is what makes a letter last; sentiment on its own does not.

3. Short is fine

   Half a page is a real letter. A paragraph is a real letter. Nobody has ever wished a letter like this had been longer.

4. Do not rewrite it

   Cross it out and carry on. The corrections are part of the record, and they are usually the most human thing on the page.

> **A note on the writing surface.** This is a paperback, and it will not lie flat on a table. If you want to write at length, it is perfectly sensible to write on a loose sheet and keep it folded inside the back cover — several of these pages are designed with room for exactly that. The book is a container, not a constraint.

PAGES I HAVE WRITTEN SEPARATELY AND KEEP IN THIS BOOK | **ADDED ON**

NOTES

Notes and things to remember

Anything that has no form field: the instruction for the boiler, the name of the man who services the car, the thing about the photographs.

ABOUT THE HOUSE

ABOUT MONEY AND PAPERWORK

ABOUT PEOPLE

NOTES

Letter

One page per person. Write the name at the top; the rest is yours.

FOR _____ **DATE** _____

Letter

FOR **DATE**

Letter

FOR **DATE**

Letter

FOR _____ **DATE** _____

CONTINUE ON A SEPARATE SHEET IF YOU NEED TO

Notes

Blank ruled pages, deliberately. Not everything worth recording has a heading.

Notes

A letter to whoever settles my estate

Not a will. A note to the person who will have to work through the paperwork, saying the things a legal document has no room for.

This letter has no legal effect, and that is the point. It can say what a will cannot: that you are sorry about the paperwork, that the second drawer is a mess, that you would rather they paid someone to help than did it alone. It can also point them at the pages of this book that matter most.

TO _____ **DATE** _____

THE PAGES THAT WILL SAVE YOU THE MOST TIME ARE 13, 82 AND 15

Every worksheet in this book

A checklist of the pages that expect writing, so you can see what is done and what is not at a glance.

PART ONE

- ☐ Ten-minute start 16
- ☐ Document system 13
- ☐ Trusted person 10
- ☐ One-page summary 15

PART TWO

- ☐ Essentials 20
- ☐ Documents to order 25
- ☐ Who to notify 21
- ☐ What goes back 24

PART THREE

- ☐ About me 29
- ☐ Family and contacts 31
- ☐ Insurance 34
- ☐ Vehicles 39
- ☐ Identification 30
- ☐ Financial institutions 36
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- ☐ Healthcare wishes 49
- ☐ Obituary 51
- ☐ Dependants and pets 53
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- ☐ Inventory 64
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- ☐ Subscriptions 72
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PART SIX

- ☐ Locator 82
- ☐ Locator 3 84
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PART SEVEN

- ☐ Review record 92
- ☐ Family conversation 98
- ☐ Change log 94

PART EIGHT

- ☐ Notes 102
- ☐ Letter to the estate 109
- ☐ Letters 103

A book with four ticks in it is worth more than a book with none.

Where to get help

A short list of official starting points. All of them are free, and none of them are selling anything.

Social Security Administration

What to do when a family member dies, survivor benefits, and the one-time payment. Publication 05-10008 is downloadable, and the national number is 1-800-772-1213.

USAGov — agencies to notify when someone dies

The current list of which organisations must be told, what stops, and what is returned. This changes, so read it rather than relying on a printed list.

USAGov — certified copies of a death certificate

Who may request one, where from, and how the rules differ for deaths abroad.

Centers for Disease Control and Prevention — Where to Write for Vital Records

A directory of the office that issues birth, death, marriage and divorce records in every state and territory.

Consumer Financial Protection Bureau

Free guidance on managing money after a death, and on what to do if a debt collector contacts you. Includes a step-by-step guide for surviving spouses.

Your state or territory's courts website

The honest answer for anything about how an estate is administered where you live. Requirements vary, and no general book can summarise them.

This book does not reproduce these pages, and deliberately does not try to keep up with them. A book is fixed on the day it is printed; a government page is not. Where the two disagree, the official page is right.

NOTES

Glossary

The words that appear in letters from institutions, in plain English. Where a term is defined differently by state law, this book says so rather than guessing.

Administrator — The person a court appoints to manage an estate when there is no will, or no executor named and able to act.

Advance directive — A document stating your wishes about medical treatment in advance. Its name, and what it must contain, differ by state.

Beneficiary — A person or organisation named to receive something — usually on an insurance policy, a retirement account or a will.

Codicil — A formal amendment to an existing will. A note in a book is not a codicil.

Death certificate — The official record of death, issued by the state or territory where it occurred. Certified copies are usually what institutions ask for.

Estate — Everything a person owns at death, including property, accounts and possessions.

Executor — The person named in a will to carry out its instructions. Also called a personal representative in some states.

Guardian — The person named to care for a minor child. Naming one is normally done in a will, and the court's approval may still be required.

Healthcare proxy — The person you authorise to make medical decisions if you cannot. The document naming them has different names in different states.

Intestate — Dying without a valid will. What happens then is set by state law, not by preference.

Joint account — An account held in more than one name. How it passes on death depends on how it is held and where you live.

Letters testamentary — A court document confirming an executor's authority. Institutions often ask for it before releasing assets.

Glossary

Notary	A public official who witnesses signatures and confirms identity. Some documents must be notarised; which ones varies by state.
Payable on death (POD)	A designation naming who receives an account when the owner dies, usually without a court process.
Personal representative	A general term for the person administering an estate — an executor or an administrator.
Power of attorney	A document authorising someone to act on your behalf. It usually ends at death, which is why an executor is a different role.
Probate	The court process for validating a will and settling an estate. Whether it is needed, and how long it takes, varies enormously.
Revocable trust	A trust you can change or cancel during your life, often used to avoid probate. Preparing one is legal work, not administrative work.
Survivor benefits	Payments some family members may be entitled to after a death, for example from Social Security. Eligibility rules are specific and worth asking about directly.
Transfer on death (TOD)	A designation naming who receives securities or property when the owner dies.
Trustee	The person or organisation responsible for managing a trust and carrying out its terms.
Two-factor authentication	A second check at sign-in, such as a code from an app. It protects an account far better than a security question.
Will	A document stating who should receive your property and who should act for your estate. Its formal requirements are set by state law.
Vital records	Birth, death, marriage and divorce records, held by the state or territory where the event occurred.

NOTES

Index of this book

Every section, with its page number. Useful when you are looking for one thing and the contents page is too broad.

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Choosing your trusted person 10
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What this can and cannot do 12
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Write the date you last checked a section in the margin beside it, or in the change log — a reader who can see that the locator was verified last spring can judge for themselves how much to rely on it.

Sources

Every factual claim in this book traces to one of these. Nothing here is invented, estimated or quoted from another book.

This organizer is deliberately thin on facts and heavy on places to write. Where it does state something as fact — the existence of a benefit, the office that issues a record, the way a copy is ordered — the source is one of the following, all official and all free.

1. Social Security Administration, *How Social Security Can Help You When a Family Member Dies* (Publication No. 05-10008)

   ssa.gov

2. USAGov, *Agencies to notify when someone dies*

   usa.gov/report-a-death

3. USAGov, *How to get a certified copy of a death certificate*

   usa.gov/death-certificate

4. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, *Where to Write for Vital Records*

   cdc.gov/nchs/w2w

5. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, *Taking Control of Your Finances: Help for Surviving Spouses*

   consumerfinance.gov

6. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, *When a loved one dies and debt collectors come calling*

   consumerfinance.gov

7. Amazon Kindle Direct Publishing, trim, margin and printing specifications

   kdp.amazon.com

Anything this book cannot source, it does not claim. Where a rule varies by state or country — which is most of the interesting questions — it says so and points to a professional instead of guessing.

Colophon

The Family Records Organizer was set in Lora, by Cyreal, for reading, and Work Sans, by Wei Huang, for labels and tables. Both are licensed under the SIL Open Font License 1.1, which permits embedding and commercial printing.

The interior was laid out as a print-ready PDF at 8.5 × 11 inches, black ink on white paper, with mirrored margins sized for a perfect-bound spine. It contains no colour, no bleed and no images, so that it prints identically on every press KDP uses.

Acknowledgement of a limitation, stated plainly: this is a paperback, and a paperback of this thickness does not lie flat. The margins and the page design were set with that in mind, and the writing areas avoid the inner edge — but the book will not sit open on a table by itself, and nothing in it pretends otherwise.

First edition.